## 9.5 Requirements of carbohydrates

The body has a specific need for carbohydrates as a source of energy for the brain and other tissue cells,for the synthesis of lactose in milk(lactating women) and galactose and other sugars present in the cerebrosides and muco-polysaccharides. The percentage of calories derived from carbohydrates in diets consumed by a vast majority of people in the developing countries is as high as 60 – 70%.The carbohydrate calories should be atleast 40% in well-balanced diets.The optimal levels of carbohydrates in the diet, taking into account the physiological needs for proteins and fats are given in table 9.2

## 9.6 Dietary fibers

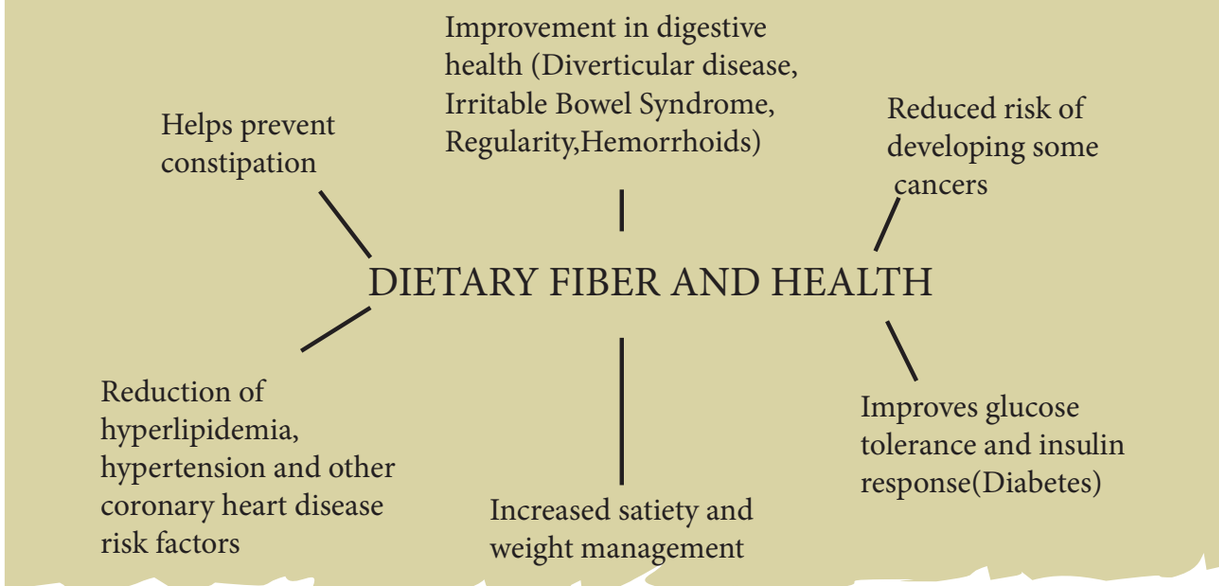
***Dietary fiber is defined as that portion of plant material ingested in the diet that is resistant to digestion by gastro intestinal secretions***. It consists of cellulose, hemicellulose, pectins, gums and mucilages as well as non-polysaccharide lignin. Some bacteria in the large intestine can degrade some components of fibre releasing products, that can be absorbed into the body and used as energy source.

**Table 9.2 Optimal level of carbohydrates in the diet**

| Age group | Optimal level of carbohydrate calories as percent of total calories |
|---|---|
| Adults | 50- 70 |
| Pregnant and lactating women | 40-60 |
| Infants(1-12 months) | 40-50 |
| Preschool (1-5 years) | 40-60 |
| Older children and adolescents | 50-70 |

**Dietary fibers**

In a nutshell..... Benefits of dietary fiber






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